

Aquifer Open Study Notes

This work is an adaptation of Tyndale Open Study Notes © 2023 Tyndale House Publishers, licensed under the CC BY-SA 4.0 license. The adaptation, Aquifer Open Study Notes, was created by Mission Mutual and is also licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0.

This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Aquifer Open Study Notes

2 Samuel 1:1

David returned from his victory: Just prior to this encounter, David and his men had killed many Amalekites because of what they had done to David's city and family (see [1 Sam 30](#)).

2 Samuel 1:1-16

An unnamed Amalekite sought out David, claiming to have killed Saul. This was a lie, as Saul had committed suicide ([1 Sam 31:4-6](#)). The Amalekite might have hoped that David would reward him for making it possible for David to assume the throne. Instead, David ordered him killed for harming the Lord's anointed.

2 Samuel 1:1-27

The forty years of Saul's reign came to a painful end. The Philistines inflicted a crushing blow on Saul's people, killing his sons and dismembering Saul's body after his suicide ([1 Sam 31](#)). On the heels of these tragedies, David's career as leader came into focus.

2 Samuel 1:4

What happened? David was not aware of what had happened to Saul—he had no part in Saul's death. • Saul and . . . Jonathan are also dead: Two other sons of Saul, Abinadab and Malkishua, were killed as well ([1 Sam 31:2](#)). The Amalekite was either unaware of their deaths or he mentioned only the son who would stand in the way of David's uncontested path to Israel's throne.

2 Samuel 1:6

The Amalekite man's second lie is, I happened to be on Mount Gilboa. Instead, he had probably scoured the area after the battle, looking for victims whose valuables he could take.

2 Samuel 1:9

Then he begged me: This is the Amalekite's third lie; instead, Saul was probably already dead (cp. [1 Sam 31:4-6](#)).

2 Samuel 1:10

The Amalekite apparently got to Saul's corpse before the Philistines did, for they would not have left royal items such as his crown and his armband on his body. • Israel's king wore a crown (Hebrew *nezer*, "consecration") as a sign of his consecration to God and status as the Lord's anointed ([1:14](#)).

2 Samuel 1:13

Where are you from? David's asking again ([1:8](#)) likely reflects the depth of his grief.

2 Samuel 1:15-16

The Amalekite expected a reward for killing David's rival but was instead condemned for killing the Lord's anointed. David himself had twice refused the opportunity to kill Saul (see [1 Sam 24:5-7](#); [26:9-11](#)).

2 Samuel 1:18

The extrabiblical Book of Jashar is no longer available. It was probably an Israelite epic poem or an anthology of poetry that covered, at minimum, Joshua's conquest of Canaan (see [Josh 10:13](#)) and the ascension of David.

2 Samuel 1:19

Your pride and joy: David's description focused more on Saul's royal position than on his personal characteristics.

2 Samuel 1:20

Gath and Ashkelon were major Philistine cities. Announcing the news of Saul's death to the Philistines would give this hated foe the opportunity to gloat and glorify their false god, Dagon, while mocking Israel's God, Yahweh. • daughters of the Philistines: In ancient war culture, young women sometimes celebrated victories in song (cp. [Exod 15:20-21](#); [1 Sam 18:7](#)).

2 Samuel 1:21

Saul and Jonathan died in the mountains of Gilboa ([1 Sam 31:1](#)). • let there be no dew or rain: David was invoking a curse on the place of their death. In a Canaanite text from the 1300s BC, a father invokes a very similar curse on the place of his son's death. • The shield of Saul symbolizes his military exploits as king. It would no longer be anointed with oil for the same reason that Saul was no longer the anointed king, because of his death.

2 Samuel 1:22

the blood of their enemies: Saul and Jonathan were known as military heroes (see [1 Sam 11:1-11](#); [14:1-23](#), [47-48](#)), though neither to the degree that David was ([1 Sam 18:7](#); [21:11](#)).

2 Samuel 1:23

beloved and gracious . . . together in life and in death: Although the relationship between Saul and Jonathan was strained, especially due to Saul's treatment of David (see [1 Sam 20:30-33](#)), Jonathan nevertheless fought and died alongside his father while defending Israel against the Philistine menace.

2 Samuel 1:26

deeper than the love of women: Jonathan's loyalty and friendship to David involved personal risk and sacrifice. This commitment was unmatched in David's experience, including the love of his wives. The phrase in no way implies a homosexual relationship. Jonathan's love for David is highlighted three times in 1 Samuel ([1 Sam 18:1](#), [3](#); [20:17](#)).

2 Samuel 2:1

David asked the Lord (cp. [5:23-24](#); [Judg 1:1-2](#); [20:18](#); [1 Sam 10:22](#)) by consulting the Urim and Thummim (see [Exod 28:30](#); [Lev 8:8](#); [Deut 33:8](#); [1 Sam 14:41](#)) administered by Abiathar, David's priest ([1 Sam 23:1-12](#); [30:7-8](#)). David acted when God directed, not before. • Hebron was nineteen miles southwest of Jerusalem. Abraham had lived in this area for a time and eventually purchased a nearby cave for a family burial plot ([Gen 23](#)). The people of the area were sympathetic toward David (see [1 Sam 30:26-31](#)).

2 Samuel 2:1-32

After Saul died, those loyal to David (the tribe of Judah) clashed with those loyal to Saul's son Ishbosheth (the remaining tribes of Israel). The Philistines, who at this time were essentially overlords of all Palestine west of the Jordan River, likely favored and encouraged this division because it made it easier for them to divide and conquer.

2 Samuel 2:2

Ahinoam: See study note on 1 Sam 25:43. David's other wife, Saul's daughter Michal, had been given to another man after David fled from Saul ([1 Sam 25:44](#)). • Abigail: See [1 Sam 25](#).

2 Samuel 2:4-7

Once established in Hebron, David made good faith gestures to those still loyal to Saul, such as the men of Jabesh-gilead. However, because they were loyal to . . . Saul and his dynasty, they rejected David as king ([2:8-11](#)). David was also in league with Nahash, king of the Ammonites (see [10:2](#); [17:27-29](#)), who had caused havoc in Jabesh-gilead ([1 Sam 11:1-15](#)).

2 Samuel 2:7

David's anointing by the people of Judah provided the legal basis of his kingship, just as it had for Saul

([1 Sam 11:15](#)). He had been anointed by the prophet Samuel years earlier ([1 Sam 16:13](#)).

2 Samuel 2:8

Abner: See study note on 1 Sam 20:25. • Mahanaim was located east of the Jordan River, deep in the highlands of Gilead near a plentiful source of fresh water. Saul and his family had close ties to Gilead ([1 Sam 11:1-11](#); [31:11-13](#)). Locating east of the Jordan made Ishbosheth's regime less susceptible to attack by David's forces. This same area was later King David's temporary refuge after Absalom's coup ([2 Sam 17:24](#), [27](#)). • *Ishbosheth* means "man of shame." His original name, *Esh-baal*, means "man of Baal." The name *Baal* ("lord, master, possessor") was associated with a pagan Canaanite deity (e.g., see [Num 25:3](#)), so it is likely that Ishbosheth's name was later changed because of that association.

2 Samuel 2:9

Gilead was the easternmost district of the northern kingdom, Jezreel the northernmost, and Benjamin the southernmost, with Ephraim in the middle. It is unclear which area was the land of the Ashurites. All the rest of Israel refers to the tribes that Ishbosheth ruled over rather than to the geographical area of his kingdom.

2 Samuel 2:10-11

Ishbosheth . . . ruled from Mahanaim for two years at some point during David's 7½-year reign from Hebron. Apparently a gap of five years occurred in which the northern tribes were without a king.

2 Samuel 2:12

Gibeon, about five miles northwest of Jerusalem, was a key city in Benjamin.

2 Samuel 2:12-32

A protracted civil war ensued between Judah (led by David) and the northern tribes (led by Saul's dynasty). These events set the stage for Abner's murder ([3:22-39](#)).

2 Samuel 2:13

The pool of Gibeon extends down some 80 feet to the water table. Archaeologists estimate that the original diggers had to remove about 3,000 tons of limestone to create it.

2 Samuel 2:14

a few of our warriors: In the ancient world, enemy armies would sometimes choose individuals or small groups to fight each other as representative gladiators—a custom often referred to as champion warfare (see also [1 Sam 17](#)). • fight hand to hand: The Hebrew term usually includes a component of play. A contest of champions might have been seen as a type of high-stakes game. In this instance, it settled nothing; the fighting expanded into a much wider confrontation with heavier casualties ([2 Sam 2:17-32](#)).

2 Samuel 2:17

The casualty count of this fierce battle is noted in [2:30-31](#).

2 Samuel 2:18

Zeruiah was David's sister ([1 Chr 2:15-16](#)), so Joab, Abishai, and Asahel were his nephews.

2 Samuel 2:20-22

Go fight someone else! . . . Get away from here! Abner's words reflect respect between peers trained for the same career, as well as a sense of fair play. The youthful Asahel would have been no match for the more experienced Abner. Abner also knew that if he killed Asahel, the conflict with David would escalate and David's forces would seek revenge (see [3:22-39](#)).

2 Samuel 2:24

they set out after Abner: See [3:27](#). • Ammah ("conduit") and Giah ("gushing") suggest that there

was an aqueduct system connected to the pool at Gibeon ([2:12-13](#)).

2 Samuel 2:26

bitterness is the only result: Realizing that such wars go on generation after generation, Abner wisely negotiated a truce.

2 Samuel 2:28

The ram's horn signaled the beginning and end of combat (see also [18:16](#); [Josh 6:15-16](#)). For other uses of the ram's horn, see study note on 2 Sam 6:15.

2 Samuel 2:29

Abner was wise to put as much distance as possible between his troops and Joab's forces, recognizing that their desire for blood vengeance could overpower the truce.

2 Samuel 2:31

The 360 who died were all from the tribe of Benjamin, Saul's tribe, under the leadership of one of Saul's relatives. This defeat was a direct blow to Saul's dynasty (cp. [3:1](#)).

2 Samuel 3:1

a long war: This civil war likely continued for most of the seven-plus years that David ruled from Hebron. The truce called by Joab and Abner ([2:26-28](#)) was short-lived.

2 Samuel 3:1-39

The house of David increased, while Saul's house dwindled. The crucial occasion came when Abner, the real political power in Saul's camp, switched allegiance to David, taking a considerable number of his northern kinsmen with him.

2 Samuel 3:2-5

One way David "became stronger and stronger" ([3:1](#)) was by taking more wives and having a son through each. Three of David's Hebron-born sons died violent deaths, two during David's reign (Amnon, Absalom), and one shortly after his death (Adonijah).

2 Samuel 3:3

Geshur was a small Canaanite kingdom in upper Transjordan (the area east of the Jordan) near the Sea of Galilee. Marrying into neighboring royal families created political alliances and secured David's position against the northern tribes. Solomon also followed this practice ([1 Kgs 3:1](#); [11:1](#)).

2 Samuel 3:7

accused Abner of sleeping with one of [Saul's] concubines: It is unclear whether Abner actually did so. Taking a king's wife or concubine was often part of a usurper's attempt to replace the king (see [12:8](#); [16:21](#); [1 Kgs 2:17-25](#)). • Rizpah: See also [2 Sam 21:8-14](#).

2 Samuel 3:8

some Judean dog: Cp. [1 Sam 17:43](#). • by not handing you over to David: Abner had control over the life and death of Saul's son.

2 Samuel 3:9

help David get what the Lord has promised him! Abner was aware that God had chosen David to be king over all Israel (see also [3:18](#)).

2 Samuel 3:10

and give it to David: Cp. [1 Sam 28:17](#). • I will establish the throne of David: Whether an ally or enemy, Abner was a powerful man. Here he speaks like God (see [2 Sam 7:13](#)).

2 Samuel 3:11

didn't dare say another word: Ishbosheth's silence speaks loudly of his weakness as a ruler. Abner, who had installed him as king ([2:8-9](#)), was the real power behind Ishbosheth's reign.

2 Samuel 3:12

In the proposed solemn pact (or *covenant*), Abner recognized that David would be king, while perhaps he hoped to be second-in-command.

2 Samuel 3:13

Saul had given his daughter Michal to David as his wife ([1 Sam 18:20-27](#)). However, when Michal saved David's life from her father ([1 Sam 19:11-17](#)), Saul terminated the marriage and gave Michal to another man, Palti ([1 Sam 25:44](#)). For David to get her back now would further cement his claim to Saul's kingdom (cp. [1 Kgs 2:13-25](#)).

2 Samuel 3:14

the lives of 100 Philistines: Saul had hoped that David would be killed in his attempt to secure the bride-price (see [1 Sam 18:17-27](#)).

2 Samuel 3:15

Ishbosheth took: Although Abner made the deal with David ([3:12-13](#)), it was Ishbosheth who gave Michal to David. This transaction illustrates Ishbosheth's weakness as a king and his fear of Abner ([3:11](#)).

2 Samuel 3:16

In spite of Palti's anguished weeping, he was powerless to stop what was happening (cp. [Judg 18:1-26](#)). • Bahurim was probably a center of support for Saul's clan just east of Jerusalem (cp. [2 Sam 16:5](#)).

2 Samuel 3:17

Apparently, there had been growing momentum among the elders of Israel in the north to accept David as king, though the text has made no mention of it to this point.

2 Samuel 3:18

See also [3:9](#). By bringing relief from the Philistines, David would accomplish what Saul had failed to do ([1 Sam 9:16](#)).

2 Samuel 3:19

Because Saul was from their tribe, the men of Benjamin no doubt viewed David, from Judah, as a usurper of Saul's throne. However, Abner was well-respected in Saul's regime and so was able to elicit support for David even among Saul's own tribe.

2 Samuel 3:21

The narrator emphasized that David sent Abner safely on his way as a friend and an ally (restated in [3:22-23](#)). David was at peace with Abner and was not involved in the renowned military leader's murder (cp. [3:28-29](#)). • Despite the murder of Abner ([3:27](#)), the northern tribes eventually did make a covenant with David to make him their king, just as Abner had promised ([5:1-3](#)).

2 Samuel 3:26

The precise location of the well of Sirah is unknown; presumably it was not far from Hebron. • David knew nothing about it: See study note on 3:21.

2 Samuel 3:27

as if to speak with him privately: Joab accused Abner of deception ([3:25](#)), but he used deception himself to lure Abner to his death. • in revenge: Joab was motivated by the practice of blood vengeance, avenging the death of a kinsman by killing the killer.

2 Samuel 3:28

David made it clear that he had nothing to do with Abner's death, labeling it as a crime. David knew that because his second-in-command had killed Abner, rumors would circulate among those loyal to Saul's dynasty that David had ordered the killing.

- I vow by the Lord: David called on the Lord to hold him accountable if he were lying.

2 Samuel 3:29

leprosy: While *leprosy* is a possible translation, the Hebrew here probably refers to a broader range of skin inflammations, not only Hansen's disease.

- who walks on crutches: This curse effectively alienated Joab from David, and from this point on they had only a professional relationship. David's deathbed order to Solomon to get rid of Joab ([1 Kgs 2:5-6](#)) and Solomon's exoneration of David in Abner's death ([1 Kgs 2:31-33](#)) indicate that David's mourning over Abner was genuine.

2 Samuel 3:30

See [2 Samuel 2:18-28](#).

2 Samuel 3:31

David himself walked: David's public presence in the mourning procession, his open weeping at the gravesite ([3:32](#)), and his dramatic fast ([3:35](#)) made evident to the public that he had not ordered Abner's killing ([3:37](#)).

2 Samuel 3:32

Burying Abner in Hebron, David's capital city at the time, rather than at some northern site reinforced Abner's shift of support from Saul to David. Presumably it encouraged others from the northern tribes to follow Abner's example.

2 Samuel 3:33

as fools die: Abner was deceived by Joab, an enemy who posed as a friend (see [3:27](#)).

2 Samuel 3:34

a wicked plot: Normal warfare could not defeat Abner, a seasoned warrior. Only treachery could.

2 Samuel 3:35

begged him to eat: See also [12:17](#).

2 Samuel 3:37

See study note on 3:31.

2 Samuel 3:39

too strong for me to control: Just as Ishbosheth could not control Abner, David could not control Joab. However, David had faith that the Lord would repay Joab for murdering Abner.

2 Samuel 4:1

all Israel became paralyzed with fear: Abner's true power was evident in Ishbosheth's reaction to his death (cp. [Josh 2:9-11](#); [5:1](#)). Ishbosheth's timidity bred the same among his followers.

2 Samuel 4:2-3

Beeroth was located in Benjamin near Gibeon. Probably because of Saul's persecution of the non-Israelite residents in that region (see [21:1-9](#)), the citizens of *Beeroth* had fled to Gittaim, the location of which is unknown.

2 Samuel 4:4

This parenthetical statement shows that, with the death of Ishbosheth ([4:5-7](#)), Saul's dynasty was unable to continue—the only other heir was a young child who was crippled (see also [9:1-13](#)).

- Mephibosheth is a nickname meaning "from the mouth of shame," possibly referring to his physical condition. No crippled animal could ever be offered to God, and no disabled priest was allowed to stand before God with the people's offerings ([Lev 21:19](#)). Likewise, Mephibosheth's condition probably disqualified him from the crown. His name change

from Merib-baal (see [1 Chr 9:40](#)) also removed association with Baal (see study note on 2 Sam 2:8).

2 Samuel 4:6

Recab and Baanah believed they would gain David's favor by committing this treacherous act.

2 Samuel 4:8

your enemy Saul: As far as we know, David never referred to Saul as an enemy. • the Lord has given . . . revenge: Wrongdoers often presume upon God's favor to justify political ambition. However, David would not reward treachery.

2 Samuel 4:9–11

Someone once told me: Cp. [1:1–16](#).

2 Samuel 4:12

cut off their hands and feet: Displaying the dismembered bodies of Ishbosheth's killers shamed them by denying them proper burial (cp. [1 Sam 31:8–13](#)); it was also a public testimony of David's innocence in Ishbosheth's death.

2 Samuel 5:1

your own flesh and blood: Years of civil war had set brother against brother, resulting in much bloodshed (see [3:1](#)).

2 Samuel 5:1–25

After the murder of Abner and Ishbosheth, the elders of the northern tribes accepted David as their king. David thus obtained an extended empire ([5:1–5](#)), a new capital city ([5:6–10](#)), a new palace ([5:11](#)), a new family ([5:13–16](#)), and renewed confidence ([5:17–25](#)).

2 Samuel 5:2

you were the one: In the ancient world, a covenant relationship (a suzerain-vassal treaty) was sometimes formed between subjects (the vassals) and a ruler (the suzerain) because of past aid, often rescue from enemies (see [Judg 8:22](#), Gideon; [Judg 11:8–11](#), Jephthah; [1 Sam 11:1–15](#), Saul). This type of relationship is the background for the covenant concept in Scripture: God was Israel's covenant Lord because he had freed them from Egypt (cp. [Exod 19:4](#); [20:1–2](#)). • the Lord told you: Israel was already aware of God's selection of David (cp. [2 Sam 3:9](#)). • shepherd of my people Israel: This phrase is quoted in [Matt 2:6](#) when King Herod asks the leading priests about the prophecies concerning the Messiah.

2 Samuel 5:3

King David made a covenant that demanded the people's loyalty, yet allowed them to maintain a sense of tribal privilege and individual dignity. It served as a constitution, containing stipulations obligating both the king and the people. • they anointed him king: While David had already been anointed by Samuel ([1 Sam 16:13](#)), this public ceremony demonstrated the people's acceptance of David as king.

2 Samuel 5:4–5

Hebron: See study note on 2:1.

2 Samuel 5:6

The Jebusites resided in Jerusalem prior to its conquest by David (see [Exod 34:11](#); [Deut 7:1–6](#); [20:17](#); [Josh 15:63](#); [Judg 1:21](#)). Nothing is known of them outside the Bible. In archaeological discoveries from Mari in Syria, a similar name (*Yabasi*) appears as both a clan name and a geographic location. • Even the blind and lame: The Jebusites had a false notion of invincibility. Another possible translation is *you won't enter here unless you can get rid of the blind and lame*, implying that David's capture of Jerusalem was as likely as achieving a miraculous cure for blindness and lameness.

2 Samuel 5:6–10

David acquired a new capital city, Jerusalem, for the newly extended kingdom.

2 Samuel 5:7

the fortress of Zion: At this time Jerusalem was probably a small site of nine to twelve square acres. The Jebusites' arrogance, and the fact that the city had not been conquered previously, suggests that it was well fortified.

2 Samuel 5:8

How David conquered Jerusalem is debated. Possibly he used a water tunnel as a conduit for his troops to enter the city, but not all interpreters agree. Another possibility is that David and his men conquered Jerusalem with the more traditional siege works and by scaling the walls. The term translated *water tunnel* occurs only here and in [Ps 42:7](#) ("raging seas"); the statement might be metaphorical, referring to the ferocity of the attack.

- The blind and the lame may not enter the house: *House* could refer either to the Temple, which had not yet been built, or to David's palace. The proverb may explain why Mephibosheth, Saul's descendant, was barred from the throne (see study note on 2 Sam 4:4).
- David also promised that those who undertook the siege of Jerusalem would become the commanders of his army (see [1 Chr 11:6](#)).

2 Samuel 5:9

made the fortress his home: Jerusalem was a practical place from which David could effectively administer the extended kingdom. It was a centrally located neutral city on the border between Judah and the northern territories, and its natural fortifications and water tunnel were useful in case of siege.

- the supporting terraces: See study note on 1 Kgs 9:15.

2 Samuel 5:10

the Lord . . . was with him: While David was a skilled and charismatic leader, his growing success was ultimately due to God's blessing.

2 Samuel 5:11

Hiram of Tyre: Although the meeting of these two neighboring kings is reported just after Jerusalem's conquest, it probably happened much later. Hiram remained on the throne in Tyre at least until Solomon's twenty-fourth year, and one ancient source notes that he had a reign of thirty-four years. Another tradition implies that Hiram became king of Tyre just eight years before Solomon became king of Israel. The same king performed a similar act for Solomon ([1 Kgs 5:1–18](#)). The report of Hiram's support is perhaps given here because it ties in with the theme of David's confirmation and establishment as Israel's king ([2 Sam 5:12](#)).

2 Samuel 5:12

David realized that his reign as king over Israel was for the sake of God's people Israel, not just for his personal benefit or enrichment.

2 Samuel 5:13–16

The expansion of David's family reflected his growing success and power as Israel's king. Solomon was David's most important Jerusalem-born son (see [12:24–25](#)).

2 Samuel 5:17–25

For the first time as king, David engaged the Philistines in battle.

- David's life has been portrayed thus far in 2 Samuel with a repeated pattern: He was crowned king in Hebron ([2:4](#)), won a battle ([2:12–17](#)), became stronger ([3:1](#)), and started a large family ([3:2–5](#)). Now he was crowned in Jerusalem ([5:3](#)), became stronger ([5:10](#)), expanded his family ([5:13–14](#)), and won a battle ([5:17–25](#)). This parallel structure draws attention to both of David's coronations with signs of divine blessing and prosperity.

2 Samuel 5:18

The valley of Rephaim is located between Bethlehem and Jerusalem (cp. [23:13–14](#)).

2 Samuel 5:20

Baal-perazim: David used the term *Baal* to honor the Lord for the victory he gave Israel. The title means “the lord of earthquakes/openings,” and was evidently an acceptable title for Yahweh until the Canaanite worship of Baal became an overwhelming problem in Israel. Every time David engaged in combat with the Philistines in 2 Samuel ([5:17-25](#); [8:1](#); [21:15-22](#); [23:13-17](#)), he won without losing a single soldier. How different from Saul, for whom victory over the Philistines was impossible!

2 Samuel 5:21

David . . . confiscated them: David’s confiscation of the Philistines’ idols was payback for their capture of the Ark during Eli’s time ([1 Sam 4:1b-11](#)). David burned the idols rather than carrying them off as trophies ([1 Chr 14:12](#)).

2 Samuel 5:23

David again asked the Lord ([5:19](#)), but this time God gave a much more detailed answer. Unlike the frontal assault of [5:20](#), God instructed David to circle around behind the enemy.

2 Samuel 5:25

Gibeon: David cleared the Philistines from the central hill country of Israel between *Gibeon* in the east (in Benjamin, north of Jerusalem) to Gezer in the west.

2 Samuel 6:1-23

Except for the brief reference in [1 Sam 14:18](#) (see note), the Ark of the Covenant has not been mentioned since [1 Sam 7:1-2](#), when the Philistines returned the captured Ark to Beth-shemesh and then to Kiriath-jearim, where it was placed in Abinadab’s home. The Ark’s virtual absence during Saul’s forty-year reign highlights that Saul, in his spiritual insensitivity, did not seek the Lord (see [1 Chr 10:13-14](#); [13:3](#)). David brought the Ark into Jerusalem, effectively acknowledging and enthroning (see [2 Sam 6:2](#)) Yahweh as the true king over Israel in the new capital.

2 Samuel 6:2

is enthroned between the cherubim: See also [1 Sam 4:4](#); [2 Kgs 19:15](#); [Pss 80:1](#); [99:1](#).

2 Samuel 6:3-4

According to God’s instructions ([Exod 25:14](#); [37:5](#); [Num 4:6](#)), the Ark was to be carried by Levites of the clan of Kohath, holding two poles slipped through four rings at the corners of the Ark. God’s instructions were ignored in this instance. • Uzzah and Ahio: In [1 Sam 7:1](#), Eleazar, another son of Abinadab, was put in charge of the Ark.

2 Samuel 6:5

The musical instruments were played by Levites ([1 Chr 16:4-6](#)).

2 Samuel 6:6-7

steadied the Ark: Although Uzzah meant well and acted instinctively, he violated the Ark by touching it (cp. [Exod 19:12-13](#); [Num 4:15](#)). He suffered the same penalty as the people from Beth-shemesh ([1 Sam 6:19](#)). David later had the Levites carry the Ark into Jerusalem in accordance with God’s will (see [1 Chr 15:2](#), [13-15](#)).

2 Samuel 6:8

David was angry . . . the Lord’s anger: Cp. [Gen 4:5](#); [1 Sam 15:11](#); [Jon 4:1](#); [Luke 15:27-28](#). • Perez-uzzah: The first part of this name appears in [2 Sam 5:20](#) (*Baal-perazim*) as the place where God burst through the Philistine ranks.

2 Samuel 6:9

David was . . . afraid: Similarly, Moses trembled at the display of divine wrath ([Deut 9:19](#)) and at the dramatic display of God’s fiery presence (see [Heb 12:21](#)).

2 Samuel 6:10

Obed-edom was a Levite ([1 Chr 15:18, 21; 16:38; 26:4, 8, 15; 2 Chr 25:24](#)) who lived either in the Philistine city of Gath or in an Israelite town of a similar name (e.g., Gath-rimmon, a city given to the Levites, [Josh 21:25](#)).

2 Samuel 6:11

God blessed Obed-edom with health, prosperity, and family. God's presence, which is a curse to the ungodly ([1 Sam 5](#)), is a blessing to his people. Obed-edom must have taken care to preserve the Ark's sanctity.

2 Samuel 6:12

David reasoned that if God blessed Obed-edom simply for storing the Ark, God would surely bless David for placing the Ark in a dwelling specifically built for it in the capital city.

2 Samuel 6:13

David offered this sacrifice of praise to God immediately, just six steps into the journey.

2 Samuel 6:14

priestly garment: This word (Hebrew 'epod, "ephod") is associated with an Akkadian word, *epattu*, meaning "a costly garment." Richly ornamented with gold, this garment was used for robing statues of gods. Because priests and (sometimes) kings were considered sacred persons, they traditionally used garments of this type (see [1 Sam 2:18, 28; 14:3; 22:18; 23:6, 9](#)).

2 Samuel 6:15

In [15:10](#), rams' horns announce the crowning of a new king; in [20:1](#), they proclaim rebellion. Here they celebrate placing the Ark in its own tent (see study note on 6:17), which in effect installed Yahweh's throne in Jerusalem.

2 Samuel 6:16

Michal is identified as the daughter of Saul three times ([6:16, 20, 23](#)). The use of her father's name underscores the ambiguity of David's relationship to her. Was she more David's wife or Saul's daughter? Had David reunited with her ([3:13](#)) because he loved her or because she was politically useful to him? • Michal might have been filled with contempt for any of the following reasons: (1) She thought David's behavior was too sexually suggestive in front of a young female audience; (2) she was jealous over the glory David was receiving while she sat at home, a neglected wife; (3) she resented David's indifference to her for many years, his taking of other wives, and her being torn away from her second husband Palti ([3:16–17](#)); or (4) she felt sorrow for her late father and David's success at the expense of Saul's dynasty (see study note on 6:21).

2 Samuel 6:17

While the special tent for the Ark was not as opulent as the tent used during the wilderness wandering, this tent was a return to the wilderness tradition suspended two generations earlier at the destruction of Shiloh ([Ps 78:60–61](#)). David's special tent was the very last Tabernacle; Solomon, David's successor, built a permanent Temple for the Lord. Because this occasion was joyous, not penitential, the sacrifice included burnt offerings and peace offerings but not sin or guilt offerings.

2 Samuel 6:18

blessed the people: Although blessing was typically the express function of priests, kings also offered blessings at significant national occasions (Solomon, [1 Kgs 8:14, 55; 2 Chr 6:3](#); Hezekiah, [2 Chr 31:8](#)).

2 Samuel 6:19

David's gifts of food to every Israelite anticipated other royal gifts they would receive under his reign.

2 Samuel 6:21

David's response to Michal might hint at the real reason for her indignation—that she resented David's success in light of the tragic decline of her father's family.

2 Samuel 6:22

David would not restrain his enthusiasm in celebrating before the Lord. In fact, he would exceed the enthusiasm he had shown thus far.

2 Samuel 6:23

Michal was the only one of David's many wives who did not bear him at least one child. Either God was punishing her (cp. [Gen 20:17–18](#)) for her disdainful attitude toward David's exuberant praise, or David and Michal's relationship had become so strained that they never again shared the marriage bed. Because Michal remained childless, yet another aspect of Saul's dynasty was cut off. This occasion is Michal's last appearance in the text.

2 Samuel 7:1

from all . . . enemies: See [Deut 12:9–10](#); [1 Kgs 5:4](#); [8:56](#). David's rest was temporary because shortly he was at war again (see [2 Sam 8:1–18](#)).

2 Samuel 7:1–2

If God had only a tent while David had a palace, it might create the impression that David was the real king rather than God. Thus, David intended to build a temple for God.

2 Samuel 7:1–29

David was not satisfied merely building a tent for the Ark ([6:17](#)). He wanted to build a house for God.

2 Samuel 7:2

Nathan is recorded in David's life on three occasions: (1) here with a promise for David; (2) in [12:1–15](#) with a parable of judgment against David;

(3) in [1 Kgs 1:11–27](#) with a plan for installing Solomon as David's successor. • A cedar palace would have been made of stone with cedar paneling inside.

2 Samuel 7:3

Go ahead and do whatever you have in mind: Nathan's counsel to David was Nathan's own idea. As it turned out, God disqualified David from building the Temple (see [1 Chr 22:8](#)). Even true prophets are fallible when speaking on their own initiative rather than from God's revelation.

2 Samuel 7:5

Are you the one? God wanted someone to build him a house, but David wasn't the right person.

2 Samuel 7:6

never lived in a house: Prior to the building of the Temple in one fixed location, God's dwelling was the Tabernacle, a mobile, tentlike structure. The text here uses language of human experience to describe a truth about God (see study notes on [Exod 29:18](#); [Deut 8:2](#)). Although God is omnipresent, he chose the Tabernacle and Temple as his "dwelling place" in ancient Israel (see study note on [2 Chr 2:5–6](#); cp. [Acts 17:24](#)).

2 Samuel 7:7

I have never once complained . . . never asked: While it was a less impressive structure than the Temple, the Tabernacle honored God because he had ordained its use for that period of Israel's history.

2 Samuel 7:8

tending sheep: Kings in the ancient Near East were often called shepherds (see [1 Kgs 22:17](#); [Isa 44:28](#); [Ezek 34:2](#); [37:24](#); [Nah 3:18](#); [Zech 10:3](#)). David, who had been a shepherd, called the Lord his shepherd ([Ps 23:1](#)).

2 Samuel 7:8-17

Instead of David's building God a house, God promised to build David a house, a permanent dynasty of kings from David's descendants.

2 Samuel 7:9

I have been with you: Through his guidance and protection, God was actively involved in shaping David's entire life. • I will make your name . . . famous: God made this promise only to Abraham and David. (see [Gen 12:2](#)).

2 Samuel 7:10-11

never be disturbed: Through David and his heirs, a lasting peace would engulf the land, in contrast with the intermittent and temporary periods of peace during the days of the judges, when one predatory nation after another shattered Israel's well-being. God's promise of rest from all your enemies was first mentioned by Joshua ([Josh 1:13, 15; 22:4](#)), and later realized in the ministry of some of the judges ([Judg 3:11, 30; 5:31; 8:28](#)).

2 Samuel 7:11

he will make a house for you: God wanted to do infinitely more for David than David could conceive of doing for God. While David was primarily interested in projects such as building a temple, God was interested in bringing blessing to his people through one righteous dynasty of kings.

2 Samuel 7:12-13

one of your descendants . . . will build a house . . . for my name: David's son Solomon would build the Temple; David's personal involvement in military conflict and bloodshed disqualified him from building God's Temple ([1 Chr 22:8-9](#)).

2 Samuel 7:14

I will be his father, and he will be my son: Kings in David's line would enjoy a special covenant relationship with God, as the whole nation of Israel did (cp. [Exod 6:7; Lev 26:12](#)). Jesus later became

the ultimate fulfillment of this prophecy (see [Heb 1:5](#)). Paul quotes this phrase in [2 Cor 6:18](#) and applies it to all believers. • If he sins, I will correct and discipline him: God would steer David's offspring, the future kings of Israel, back onto the right track whenever they sinned. Cp. the experience of Jesus, who never sinned, yet endured God's discipline (see [Heb 4:15; 5:8; 12:1-11](#)).

2 Samuel 7:16

for all time . . . forever: God's promises do not negate human responsibility and accountability ([7:14](#)). Wrongdoing requires a just response from God. However, no wayward son of David could move God to withdraw his promise to preserve David's dynasty. Although the dynasty disappeared for hundreds of years, David's house and kingdom were renewed in Jesus Christ, the sinless descendant of David who reigns forever.

2 Samuel 7:18

David's question, "Who am I?" was an expression of genuine humility (cp. [Exod 4:11](#)).

2 Samuel 7:18-29

David responded prayerfully to God's promise of a dynasty, repeatedly acknowledging God's true kingship as Sovereign Lord.

2 Samuel 7:19

God's plan to give David a lasting dynasty stretched well beyond his lifetime. The promise is fulfilled forever in the eternal reign of Christ ([Rev 11:15](#)).

2 Samuel 7:20

You know what your servant is really like: God made his promises to David with full knowledge that David had both strengths and weaknesses.

2 Samuel 7:21

God's will, rather than David's personal ambition, enabled David to accomplish great things. • you have done: David spoke of what God promised to do for his heirs over the generations as an already-accomplished fact, showing his unshakable belief in God's faithfulness.

2 Samuel 7:22

There is no one like you: David affirms God's uniqueness (see also [22:32](#); [Deut 4:39](#); [1 Sam 2:2](#)).

2 Samuel 7:23

Israel was set apart from every other nation by the uniqueness of its God and by the relationship the people had with him.

2 Samuel 7:24

David praised God for his goodness in redeeming and establishing the nation of Israel ([7:23-24](#)), not just David and his royal line ([7:18-21](#)). His prayer is corporate rather than just personal.

2 Samuel 7:25

Confirm it: David was not asking God for a sign (as Gideon had done, [Judg 6:17](#)). Rather, David was saying, "God, may it be so."

2 Samuel 7:26

Although God had promised to make David's name great ([7:9](#)), David was concerned that God's name be honored. David knew that if God were not the focus of the people's praise, then David's dynasty would count for nothing.

2 Samuel 8:1-18

The expansion of David's empire through military victories ([8:1-14](#)) and the establishment of his royal bureaucracy ([8:15-18](#)) fulfilled God's promise of a famous name ([7:9](#); cp. [8:13](#)).

2 Samuel 8:2

Moab was on the east side of the Dead Sea. Earlier, the people of Moab had provided David's parents with refuge during Saul's reign ([1 Sam 22:3-4](#)); David's great-grandmother, Ruth, was from Moab. For whatever reason, no such fraternal relationship existed any longer. • two groups to be executed for every one group to be spared: This is the only time in 2 Samuel that David executed captives taken in battle (see [Num 21:29](#); [24:17](#); [Deut 2:9](#)).

2 Samuel 8:3

Hadadezer reappears in [10:16](#) as David's foe. He was either the direct son of Rehob and his successor or the reigning king of a dynasty established by a king named Rehob, whose kingdom was near the northern city of Dan (see [Judg 18:28](#); cp. [Num 13:21](#)). • Zobah was north and east of David's kingdom. • It is possible that David, not Hadadezer (literally *he*), marched out to strengthen his control. • the Euphrates River: Literally *the river*; [1 Chr 18:3](#) specifically identifies the Euphrates. Cp. [2 Sam 10:16](#).

2 Samuel 8:4

David would have crippled . . . horses to prevent their reuse by the enemy and because kings in Israel were not to accumulate horses ([Deut 17:16](#)).

2 Samuel 8:5

Hadadezer's neighbors, Arameans from Damascus, were of no help to him in repelling David. They would later be more successful against Solomon ([1 Kgs 11:23-25](#)) but less successful in their attack of Samaria during the days of King Ahab of Israel ([1 Kgs 20](#)).

2 Samuel 8:6

David established army garrisons in Aram but not in Moab ([8:2](#)), which suggests that Aram was a more formidable force and that David needed a military presence there to maintain control. • the

Lord made David victorious: Cp. [8:14](#). God was the real source of David's growth and power.

2 Samuel 8:7

gold shields: See also [2 Kgs 11:10](#). • brought . . . to Jerusalem: In conformity with God's stipulations for a good king ([Deut 17:17](#)), David dedicated these valuable items to God (see [2 Sam 8:11](#)) rather than hoarding them for his own wealth and splendor.

2 Samuel 8:9

Hamath was northwest of Hadadezer's Zobah.

2 Samuel 8:10

his son: King Toi dispatched the crown prince rather than another entourage on this mission because he considered it vital to stay properly connected with David. • Joram: The prefix *Jo-* is an abbreviated form of Yahweh; *Joram* means "Yahweh is exalted." In [1 Chr 18:10](#) the prince's name is Hadoram, which means "Hadad [a Canaanite god] is exalted." It is possible that Toi changed the prince's name for diplomatic reasons, to make it more agreeable to David.

2 Samuel 8:11-12

Captured war booty and diplomatic exchanges went into God's treasury rather than the king's treasury. Voluntary gifts ([8:11a](#)) and plunder exacted from defeated foes ([8:11b-12](#)) also were dedicated . . . to the Lord.

2 Samuel 8:13-14

These two verses highlight three of David's war policies: (1) inflict heavy damage on the enemy (18,000 casualties); (2) reduce them to vassalage (they became David's subjects); (3) place army garrisons in the conquered territory to maintain control over them. • Edomites: This name is very similar to *Arameans* in old Hebrew script. *Edomites* is more likely, however, because the Valley of Salt (the Dead Sea area) was adjacent to Edomite, not Aramean, territory.

2 Samuel 8:15-18

David's bureaucracy included (1) military officials (Joab); (2) a court historian (Jehoshaphat); (3) priests (Zadok and Ahimelech); (4) a scribe or court secretary (Seraiah); and (5) a security officer (Benaiah, who became a commander under Solomon; see also [1 Kgs 2:25-46](#)).

2 Samuel 8:18

- The king's bodyguard included the *Cherethites* and *Pelethites*, who were likely foreigners. The Cherethites might have come from Crete (see also [1 Samuel 30:14](#); [Ezekiel 25:16](#)). These groups could have been Philistine mercenaries.
- *David's sons were priestly leaders:* David was from Judah and not a Levite (only people from the tribe of Levi could usually serve as priests). David may have created a new group of religious servants connected to his family line of kings to serve the king's court. This was different from the normal priests who served at the temple (see also study note on 2 Samuel 20:26).

2 Samuel 9:1

show kindness: The Hebrew word (*khesed*) speaks of covenant loyalty and faithfulness. The word frequently describes God's commitment to his people, but it can also describe the devotion and loyalty between any two persons. David's use of the word here echoes the language of the covenant of friendship between himself and Jonathan ([1 Sam 20:12-17](#)). • for Jonathan's sake: Mephibosheth was Saul's only remaining descendant and the only son of Jonathan.

2 Samuel 9:1-13

David showed mercy to Mephibosheth, Jonathan's crippled son. The incident is sandwiched between

David's victories in battle ([8:1-18](#), [10](#)), indicating that David also had concern for individuals and a compassionate heart.

2 Samuel 9:3

Mephibosheth was crippled in both feet from a childhood accident (see [4:4](#)).

2 Samuel 9:4

Lo-debar was a small town in northern Transjordan (the area east of the Jordan), close to Mahanaim, the capital city of Mephibosheth's late uncle, Ishbosheth. The town was also near Jabesh-gilead, where Saul first made a name for himself ([1 Sam 11:1-13](#)). • Makir son of Ammiel, Mephibosheth's host, later supported David during Absalom's revolt ([2 Sam 17:27](#)).

2 Samuel 9:5

As Saul had once sent for David ([1 Sam 16:19](#)), now David sent for Mephibosheth. However, Saul sent for someone to minister to him, whereas David sent for someone to whom he could minister.

2 Samuel 9:6

Given Mephibosheth's physical limitations, bowing low to the ground must have been very difficult.

2 Samuel 9:7

David had confiscated all the property that had belonged to . . . Saul.

2 Samuel 9:8

a dead dog like me: Mephibosheth knew that anyone with a possible claim to the throne might be killed as a threat.

2 Samuel 9:11

Both Ziba and Mephibosheth ([9:6](#)) used the phrase "I am your servant" when presenting themselves before King David. By referring to himself as David's servant, Ziba showed that he was no longer loyal to Saul's dynasty. The sincerity of both later came into question ([16:1-4](#); [19:17-30](#)).

2 Samuel 9:13

crippled in both feet: See [4:4](#).

2 Samuel 10:1

Some time after this: King Hadadezer appears in [10:1-19](#) as David's active and capable foe ([10:16](#)), yet in [8:1-18](#) David had defeated him ([8:3](#)) and plundered his city ([8:7](#), [12](#)). Either Hadadezer was still alive, had regrouped, and revolted in [10:1-19](#); or possibly [10:1-19](#) unpacks the events of [8:1-18](#) as a prelude to [11:1-27](#).

2 Samuel 10:1-5

The king of Ammon insulted David's ambassadors, which led to two battles between Israel and Ammon ([10:6-12:31](#)).

2 Samuel 10:1-19

Following the interlude of ch [9](#), the narrative returns to David's military feats. The Ammonites were likely the dominant political power in Transjordan (the area east of the Jordan) during Saul's reign and the early years of David's reign.

2 Samuel 10:2

In both chs [9](#) and [10](#), David wanted to show loyalty (khesed; also in [9:1](#), [3](#)).

2 Samuel 10:4

Shaving half of each man's beard was intended to maximize the humiliation and ridicule. • cut off their robes: The humiliating display of genitalia or

the buttocks was associated with military defeat and exile ([Isa 20](#)).

2 Samuel 10:5

The city of Jericho had not yet been formally reconstructed (see [1 Kgs 16:34](#)), but the site was located adjacent to the largest and most plentiful spring in the land, so people continued to dwell in the area. Anyone traveling from Ammon to Jerusalem would pass right by it. It was a place of seclusion from the men's humiliation.

2 Samuel 10:6

Aramean foot soldiers: See [8:5-6](#). • Beth-rehob and Zobah: See [8:3](#), [12](#). • the land of Tob (literally *the man of Tob*) possibly refers to a vassal king and region under Hadadezer's sovereignty.

2 Samuel 10:8

The Israelites had a double battle: against the Ammonites in front of their fortifications at the entrance of the city gate and against the Aramean army in the open fields.

2 Samuel 10:12

Be courageous! Often the priest or another leader offered prebattle exhortations (cp. [Num 31:6](#); [Deut 20:2](#); [Judg 4:14](#); [1 Sam 4:4](#); [14:3](#); [23:9](#)).

2 Samuel 10:16

Hadadezer: See study note on 10:1. • Helam is unknown. • Apparently David had extended his empire as far north as the Euphrates River (see also study note on 8:3).

2 Samuel 11:1

In the spring of the year, the land began to dry out after the heavy winter rains. Kings avoided war during the rainy season. • David stayed behind either because he was irresponsible in carrying out his royal duties or because he trusted Joab to

efficiently handle the Ammonite problem (cp. [10:7](#)). This is the first mention of a leader of Israel staying off the battlefield in a time of war.

2 Samuel 11:1-27

David's affair with Bathsheba and the murder of her husband Uriah show that David was capable of great failure and cast a dark shadow over David's life and career. These failures came during a time of great military success against the Ammonites ([10:1-11:1](#); [12:26-31](#)).

2 Samuel 11:2

walking on the roof: The roofs of houses were flat and were regularly used for a variety of purposes, such as drying and storing produce ([Josh 2:6](#)), strolling and socializing, and sleeping in warm weather. • Bathsheba was taking a bath in plain view of the roof of the king's palace, but perhaps she assumed everyone would be inside, seeking refuge from the heat or having a midday rest.

2 Samuel 11:3

Bathsheba means "daughter of seven" or "daughter of oath." Her father Eliam was the son of Ahithophel (see [23:34](#)), an adviser sought by David and then by Absalom ([15:12](#); [16:23](#)). Much to David's chagrin ([15:31](#)), Ahithophel later shifted his allegiance from David to Absalom ([17:1-4](#), [14](#)) and advised Absalom to sleep with David's concubines on a rooftop, in open view ([16:20-22](#)). • Uriah is a Hebrew name (meaning "Yahweh [is] my light"); either he was a foreign mercenary, a convert to Israelite religion, or an Israelite of Hittite heritage. Uriah might also have been a member of the non-Israelite aristocracy in Jerusalem that predated David's conquest of the city. He was one of the Thirty—David's mightiest warriors ([23:39](#)).

2 Samuel 11:4

It is not clear whether Bathsheba came to David's palace voluntarily. That no protestations are recorded (cp. [13:12-13](#)) and that she married David, bore him another child, and persuaded him to designate their child as heir ([1 Kgs 1:11-21](#)) suggest that she might have been a willing partner.

However, Bathsheba mourned for her husband ([2 Sam 11:26-27](#)), and only David was condemned for this act ([11:27](#)), so she might have been violated against her will. • The phrase after having her menstrual period (see [Lev 15:19-24](#)) is included to show that the child Bathsheba conceived could not possibly have been Uriah's.

2 Samuel 11:8

and relax: David assumed that Uriah would have sex with Bathsheba while on this weekend pass. Then everyone except Bathsheba would assume that the child was Uriah's, conceived on this night. • a gift: David might not have even cared whether the husband and wife were intimate. Uriah's return to his house would stifle any rumors as to how and when Bathsheba became pregnant.

2 Samuel 11:11

- *in tents* (Hebrew, *sukkoth*, the name behind *Sukkot*, "the Feast of Tabernacles," [Deuteronomy 16:13-17](#)): These were temporary shelters made of branches and leaves. Soldiers in battle, herders watching their animals, or workers during the grape harvest used these shelters.
- *eat and drink and sleep with my wife?*: Uriah was willing to eat and drink with David ([2 Samuel 11:13](#)). What he refused was to sleep with his wife, Bathsheba. In ancient Israel, soldiers on duty treated the camp as a holy place because they believed God was present there to fight for them. For that reason, they avoided anything considered impure, including sexual relations ([Leviticus 15:18](#); see also [1 Samuel 21:5-6](#)).

2 Samuel 11:16-17

Uriah was not the only casualty: David sacrificed several other Israelite soldiers while attempting to hide his sin.

2 Samuel 11:21

Wasn't Abimelech ... killed ... by a woman: Cp. [Judg 9:54](#).

2 Samuel 11:25

The sword devours this one today and that one tomorrow! David's callous attitude toward the unnecessary deaths he caused is chilling.

2 Samuel 12:1

The Lord sent Nathan to David at least nine months after his adulterous sin. • This story is a rare Old Testament instance of a parable (see also [Judg 9:8-15](#)). Such stories can be effective for communicating truth. • David was rich in the royal treasures he possessed, the number of wives he had, and all the promises of God for his future. Uriah by contrast was poor: he had one wife, one home, and no lineage.

2 Samuel 12:1-31

Chapter 12 expands on the last phrase of [11:27](#).

2 Samuel 12:3

like a baby daughter: Nathan's comparison of this lamb to a daughter (Hebrew *bath*) strikes a parallel with Bathsheba's name (see study note on 11:3).

2 Samuel 12:4

he took the poor man's lamb: Samuel had previously warned that a king would take what was not his ([1 Sam 8:11-17](#)).

2 Samuel 12:5-6

The rich man of the parable did not deserve to die according to the law; instead, he must repay four lambs (cp. [Exod 22:1](#)). Intriguingly, David would later lose four of his sons (Bathsheba's first child, [2 Sam 12:18](#); Amnon, [13:29](#); Absalom, [18:14-15](#); Adonijah, [1 Kgs 2:25](#)).

2 Samuel 12:7-8

You are that man! David did deserve to die for his crime ([Lev 20:10](#)). • I anointed . . . I gave . . . I would have given you: David's sin not only violated God's commandments against murder, adultery, and coveting ([Exod 20:1-17](#)) but also amounted to a brazen disregard for all that the Lord had graciously given him.

2 Samuel 12:8

His wives were probably the concubines of Saul's harem (cp. [3:7](#)). The phrase could refer to Saul's wife Ahinoam, although David probably married a different woman with the same name (cp. [1 Sam 14:50](#); [25:43](#)).

2 Samuel 12:10

from this time on (literally *forever*): Contrast God's gracious "forever" promises of [7:13-29](#). • The reminder of what David had done with the sword ([12:9](#)) and what role *the sword* would play in his family recalls David's cavalier response to Joab's report of the deaths of Uriah and other innocent Israelites ([11:25](#)).

2 Samuel 12:11

I will cause your own household to rebel against you: Absalom's revolt against David (chs [14-19](#)) fulfilled this promise.

2 Samuel 12:14

Nevertheless . . . your child will die: At times, God transfers punishment of fathers to their descendants ([Exod 20:5](#); [34:7](#); [Num 14:18](#); [Deut 5:9](#); [Jer 32:18](#)). Although David repented and was forgiven ([2 Sam 12:13](#)), it did not cancel all retribution; it delayed it until a later generation (cp. [1 Kgs 21:27-29](#)).

2 Samuel 12:20

The series of actions described here show David resuming normal life activities. That he did so this soon after his son's death amazed his advisers ([12:21](#)).

2 Samuel 12:21-23

David grieved before his son's death, hoping to ward off punishment.

2 Samuel 12:23

Can I bring him back again? I will go to him one day: The irreversibility of his son's death forced David to face his own mortality. But he also showed his confidence in the afterlife.

2 Samuel 12:24

Even after Uriah's death, Bathsheba was still called Uriah's wife ([12:9](#); see also [Matt 1:6](#)). Only here is she called David's wife. • Solomon: Pronounced Shelomoh in Hebrew, it probably means "his peace," from the Hebrew shalom. It might mean "his replacement"; cp. *Shelemiah* ([Jer 36:14](#), "Yahweh has provided compensation") and *Shelumiel* ([Num 1:6](#), "God [is] my compensation"); both contain the root shelem ("replacement, compensation").

2 Samuel 12:25

Jedidiah means "loved by Yahweh." This God-given second name for Solomon, mentioned only here, guaranteed his future, as it expressed God's special love for him.

2 Samuel 12:26-31

David's battle with the Ammonites, begun in ch [10](#), ended in success.

2 Samuel 12:30

David removed the crown: David had, in effect, become the Ammonites' king. • a vast amount of

plunder: Instructions against taking such booty during a conquest ([Deut 7:25-26](#)) show how dangerous David's actions were. Such wealth might seduce the king's heart away from God.

2 Samuel 12:31

He also made slaves of the people of Rabbah and forced them to labor with: Enslaving defeated peoples was in accord with [Deut 20:11](#). Solomon later did the same with the Canaanites ([1 Kgs 9:20-22](#); see also [Judg 1:30, 33](#)). The alternate reading might indicate torture inflicted on the defeated Ammonites (cp. [textual note on 1 Chr 20:3](#)).

2 Samuel 13:1

Absalom had a beautiful sister: Tamar was Absalom's full sister but Amnon's half sister (see [3:2-3](#)). Absalom would later avenge Tamar as her nearest relative ([13:23-29](#); cp. [Gen 34](#); [Num 35:19](#)).

2 Samuel 13:2

obsessed... ill: As the story reveals, Amnon's "love" ([13:4](#)) for Tamar was a sickly erotic obsession. • She was a virgin: Amnon's fixation deepened because Tamar was sexually untouched. • thought he could never have her: The law prohibited marriage between brother and sister ([Lev 18:9, 11; 20:17; Deut 27:22](#)). But Amnon did not want to marry Tamar; he only wanted to have sex with her.

2 Samuel 13:3

crafty (literally *wise*): Jonadab's "wisdom" was akin to the serpent's shrewdness ([Gen 3:1](#)). • In the context of a royal court, the Hebrew term for friend is closer to "counselor" or "adviser."

2 Samuel 13:4

morning after morning: Amnon's obsession was all-consuming and ongoing.

2 Samuel 13:12

wicked things: The Hebrew word *nebalah* ("outrage," "deplorable act") often describes sexual crimes such as rape and adultery ([Gen 34:7](#); [Deut 22:21](#); [Judg 20:6, 10](#); [Jer 29:23](#)) that the perpetrator must pay for with his life. • in Israel: The addition of this phrase either indicates indignation that the crime happened among Israelites or characterizes the act as a violation of Israelite standards of sexual morality.

2 Samuel 13:13

he will let you marry me: Tamar said this to gain time; Amnon knew that the law prohibited marriage between half siblings (see study note on [13:2](#)), and he refused to back off.

2 Samuel 13:14

since he was stronger: Tamar resisted as much as she could.

2 Samuel 13:15

That Amnon's feelings for Tamar so quickly turned to hate shows that his so-called "love" for her ([13:4](#)) was really only selfish lust.

2 Samuel 13:16

worse than what you've already done: A virgin who had been raped became unmarriageable ([13:20](#); see [Deut 22:28-29](#)).

2 Samuel 13:18

a long, beautiful robe: The same phrase is used to describe Joseph's robe in [Gen 37:3](#).

2 Samuel 13:19

Tamar tore her robe to symbolize the violation of her virginity and honor and to mourn the death of her future ([13:16](#)). • Ashes represented death; sitting amid ashes or putting ashes on one's head

were signs of mourning ([Esth 4:1–3](#); [Job 42:6](#); [Dan 9:3](#); [Jon 3:6](#)).

2 Samuel 13:20

keep quiet for now . . . Don't you worry about it: Absalom's words of comfort seem hollow in light of her disgrace and mourning; this toned-down response hid Absalom's rage ([13:22](#)) from the already distraught Tamar. • as a desolate woman: See study note on 13:16.

2 Samuel 13:21

King David . . . was very angry: But he apparently never punished Amnon—as in the Dead Sea Scrolls and Greek version, which add that it was because he loved Amnon. Another possibility is that as an adulterer himself (see [11:1–12:24](#)), David considered himself in no position to punish his son's sexual sin. A third possibility is that David thought this was God's "eye for an eye" punishment for his own sexual indiscretion.

2 Samuel 13:23

- Baal-hazor is different from the well-known fortified city of Hazor, which is north of the Sea of Galilee. A fortified city is a city protected by strong walls and defenses. Baal-hazor is believed to be at Jebel el-Asur, about 24 kilometers (15 miles) north of Jerusalem.
- *he invited all the sons of the king:* Sheep shearing was a time to share abundance and blessings with others (see [1 Samuel 25:2–8](#)).

2 Samuel 13:31

David tore his robe, as Tamar had done after being violated ([13:19](#))—a sign of great distress or remorse (see also [Gen 37:34](#)).

2 Samuel 13:34–39

Absalom, now a fugitive, sought refuge among his mother's family.

2 Samuel 13:37

fled to his grandfather: See [3:3](#). • Geshur was in Aram, northeast of Israel's territory (see [15:8](#); [Josh 13:13](#)).

2 Samuel 13:39

And King David: Dead Sea Scrolls and Greek version read *And the spirit of the king*. • longed to be reunited with his son Absalom: David's grief over Amnon's death was evidently alleviated; any desire David might have had to execute Absalom had dissipated.

2 Samuel 14:2

The woman with a reputation for great wisdom was summoned to carry out a delicate mission in the royal court (cp. [20:16](#)).

2 Samuel 14:9

If you are criticized: If David allowed a murder to go unavenged, he would be liable for not carrying out justice and would likely draw criticism.

2 Samuel 14:11

As surely as the Lord lives: When the woman pressed David for a greater commitment of protection, David responded with this solemn oath (cp. [4:9](#); [12:5](#); [15:21](#); [1 Sam 20:3](#); [28:10](#); [29:6](#)).

2 Samuel 14:13

for the people of God: The woman argued that David was harming everyone in his kingdom by leaving Absalom in exile, perhaps because alienation in the royal family would be reproduced in the larger society or because David's obsession with Absalom would distract him from attending to more important matters ([14:16](#)).

2 Samuel 14:14

God . . . devises ways: The woman encouraged David to be reconciled with Absalom as God does with his people. God did not remain estranged from David when he sinned; he forgave the repentant king.

2 Samuel 14:16

The woman again addressed her specific situation. The king's concern for Absalom (see [13:39](#) and corresponding note) was keeping him from attending to matters of justice among his people. • cut us off: If her only remaining son were killed, the woman's family would lose ownership of its ancestral property (cp. [Num 27:1–11](#)).

2 Samuel 14:17

you are like an angel of God: This flattering expression is not used for anyone else in the Bible but appears four times to describe David (see also [14:20](#); [19:27](#); [1 Sam 29:9](#)). The woman was expressing confidence that David would act with God-given wisdom and justice.

2 Samuel 14:20

as wise as an angel of God: This wise woman ([14:2](#)) knew it was good policy to flatter a king rather than risk insulting him.

2 Samuel 14:21

bring back . . . Absalom: It seems that David was not yet interested in full reconciliation with his son ([14:24](#)).

2 Samuel 14:23

Geshur: See [2 Samuel 13:37–38](#).

2 Samuel 14:26

cut his hair only once a year: Absalom's hair, an aspect of his attractiveness, ended up being a deadly snare for him (see [18:9–15](#)).

2 Samuel 14:27

Absalom's three sons apparently died before he did (see [18:18](#)). • Absalom named his daughter Tamar after his sister, and she too was very beautiful ([13:1](#)).

2 Samuel 14:29

Joab persuaded David to welcome Absalom back ([14:21–22](#)) but then backed off from assisting Absalom further; perhaps Joab wanted to avoid aiding a would-be usurper ([15:1–12](#)).

2 Samuel 14:33

Absalom bowed low, assuming a posture of respect and deference to the king's majesty (see also [14:4, 22](#)). • and the king kissed him: The lack of conversation, hugging (cp. [Luke 15:20](#)), or weeping (cp. [Gen 33:4](#); [45:2, 14](#)) suggests that this was a formal meeting rather than an affectionate reunion.

2 Samuel 15:1

a chariot and horses, and . . . fifty bodyguards: These three items, distinct signs of kingship, were also the first items that Samuel said the king would take from the people ([1 Sam 8:11](#)). Another of David's sons, Adonijah, collected the same items when he coveted the throne ([1 Kgs 1:5](#)).

2 Samuel 15:1–19

Absalom revolted against David eleven years after Amnon violated Tamar (cp. [13:23, 38](#); [14:28](#); [15:7](#)), approximately the twenty-fifth year of David's thirty-three-year reign in Jerusalem.

2 Samuel 15:5

To bow before . . . Absalom was, in effect, to honor him as king (see [14:33](#)).

2 Samuel 15:6

stole the hearts: Absalom's accessibility and false pretense of care for the people gained their loyalty.

2 Samuel 15:7

After four years: Hebrew reads *forty years*, which would put Absalom's uprising in David's last year as king and create many chronological difficulties with events that happened afterward (also see study note on 15:1–19). The Greek and Syriac reading is much more likely. • fulfill a vow: Unlike the freewill offering of devotion and gratitude that a worshiper promised to God, this type of offering was to fulfill a promise to God (see [Gen 28:20–22](#); [Judg 11:30–31](#); [1 Sam 1:11](#)). Absalom was probably lying (cp. [1 Sam 20:28–29](#)).

2 Samuel 15:8

Geshur in Aram: After killing Amnon, Absalom had sought refuge in the homeland of his mother (also see study notes on 13:34–39, 37). • The perfect place for Absalom to turn his grassroots popularity into a full-fledged revolt against David was in Hebron, David's first capital.

2 Samuel 15:12

Ahithophel was Bathsheba's grandfather (cp. [11:3](#); [23:34](#)); years later, he might still have been angry over what David did to his granddaughter. • Giloh was located in the region of Hebron ([Josh 15:51, 54](#)).

2 Samuel 15:15–16

Possibly David left ten of his concubines behind because he believed his exile would be short-lived. See [16:21–22](#).

2 Samuel 15:18

- *six hundred Gittites*: This alliance began with David's connection to the Philistines during Saul's time ([1 Samuel 21:10–15](#); [27:1–12](#); [29:1–11](#)).
- *the Cherethites and Pelethites*: Refer to the study note on 2 Samuel 8:18.

2 Samuel 15:19

Ittai, a Philistine from Gath, was associated with Gibeah in Benjamin ([23:29](#); [1 Chr 11:31](#)); the Philistines had established a garrison in Gibeah at the beginning of Saul's career ([1 Sam 10:5](#); [13:3](#)). • David was stepping aside for King Absalom, who had successfully swayed the loyalty of Israel.

2 Samuel 15:23

The Kidron Valley, east of Jerusalem, separated the City of David from the Mount of Olives.

2 Samuel 15:24

Zadok was one of two priests who served David ([8:17](#)). He later anointed Solomon ([1 Kgs 1:39](#)) and became the high priest after Abiathar was deposed ([1 Kgs 2:26–27](#)).

2 Samuel 15:25

take the Ark of God back: People fleeing invasion normally took their idols to avoid having the items fall into an enemy's hands. The capture of a god could be interpreted by rebel elements to mean that the gods had abandoned the ruling dynasty. However, the Ark was not a mere idol or talisman (cp. [1 Sam 4:3–11](#); [5:6–6:9](#)). It was the central object in the sanctuary and represented the presence of the Lord, the God of Israel (see [Exod 40:34–35](#)). David intentionally permitted the Ark to fall into Absalom's hands, trusting God's grace and promises ([2 Sam 15:26](#); see [7:8–16](#)) whether or not the Ark was with him.

2 Samuel 15:27

Ahimaaz and Jonathan supported David during Absalom's coup d'état by serving as his secret messengers (see [15:36](#); [17:17-22](#)).

2 Samuel 15:31

let Ahithophel give . . . foolish advice: David also sent a double-agent, Hushai, to confound Ahithophel's advice ([15:32-37](#); [17:1-14](#)).

2 Samuel 15:32

At this point in Israel's history, people worshiped God at multiple altars across the land. The Tabernacle as it had existed from the time of Joshua and Samuel was gone and the Temple was yet to be built. • An Arkite was possibly a non-Israelite from the region south of Bethel ([Josh 16:2](#)).

2 Samuel 15:34

While David was confident that God's providence was at work behind the scenes, he also took strategic action to further his own cause.

2 Samuel 16:1

Ziba: See study note on 9:11; see also [9:1-13](#); [19:24-30](#). • As Saul's grandson ([16:3](#)), Mephibosheth was a potential rival for the throne.

2 Samuel 16:3-4

Ziba was lying to David for his own gain; Mephibosheth later set the record straight ([19:24-30](#)).

2 Samuel 16:5

Bahurim was in the territory of Benjamin east of the Mount of Olives on the way to the Jordan River. It is likely that many people from Benjamin, Saul's tribe, harbored lingering resentment against David's rule. In the case of Shimei, his loyalty to Saul was even stronger because he was from the same clan in the tribe of Benjamin.

2 Samuel 16:7-8

Shimei cursed David, holding him responsible for the violent death of Saul and his clan.

2 Samuel 16:8

The Lord is paying you back: Shimei interpreted Absalom's rebellion as the Lord's retribution. However, David was innocent (see study notes on 1:4, 15-16).

2 Samuel 16:9

Abishai was David's nephew ([1 Chr 2:13-16](#)) and evidently a member of his personal guard. He believed that no one should talk this way to the king and live to tell about it (cp. [2 Sam 19:21](#)). David was slower to judge (cp. [1 Kgs 2:8-9](#)).

2 Samuel 16:10

If the Lord has told him to curse me: David felt it might have been punishment for past sins. • David was—contrary to Shimei's charges—reducing the violence that surrounded him.

2 Samuel 16:11-12

even more reason: David understood why a supporter of Saul might hate him.

2 Samuel 16:16

Long live the king! Hushai's words were deliberately ambiguous. He was in fact an agent of the true king—David was truly "the man . . . chosen by the Lord" ([16:18](#)). Hushai avoided using the king's name, leading Absalom to believe that Hushai was loyal to him rather than to David.

2 Samuel 16:19

why shouldn't I serve you? (literally *and second, to whom will I do service? Not before his son?*): The ambiguous language continues. Hushai phrased his

profession of loyalty as a question rather than as a commitment. His intent, lost on Absalom, was to serve David while fooling Absalom into thinking that he had changed sides. Similarly, just as I was your father's adviser, now I will be your adviser! is literally, *as I served before your father, so I will [serve your father] before you*.

2 Samuel 16:21

Go and sleep with your father's concubines: A usurper took a predecessor's harem to assert or strengthen his claim to the throne (see [3:7](#)). Absalom's action was in violation of [Deut 22:30](#).

2 Samuel 16:22

Absalom intended to show the people that he had assumed the throne with its royal prerogatives. His shameful act echoed David's adultery with Bathsheba, which also began on that roof ([11:2-4](#)); the episode fulfilled Nathan's prophecy ([12:11-12](#)).

2 Samuel 16:23

from the mouth of God: Cp. [17:14](#).

2 Samuel 17:1-14

Ahithophel proposed a quick surprise strike against David with a small force (12,000 men, [17:1](#)), which would give David no time to organize and fight back. Then David's double-agent Hushai suggested taking more time to mobilize the entire army of Israel ([17:11](#)). This plan would supposedly give them an insurmountable numerical advantage and prevent David from engaging in guerilla tactics. Because the Lord was working against Absalom, he rejected Ahithophel's good strategy and accepted Hushai's bad advice ([17:14](#); cp. [1 Kgs 12:1-15](#)).

2 Samuel 17:3

as a bride . . . you seek: The Hebrew text has the loyalty of all the people depend on the death of David. The Greek version pictures a young wife who returns to her husband after a short quarrel.

2 Samuel 17:11

The nationwide military conscription from . . . Dan to Beersheba (the northern and southern limits of Israel) was intended to produce an overwhelmingly superior fighting force.

2 Samuel 17:14

Ahithophel's strategy was actually better. However, Hushai had the psychological and rhetorical advantage as well as the Lord's purpose, so he won Absalom's favor. • the Lord had determined to defeat: Despite early advances, Absalom's power grab was doomed from the start.

2 Samuel 17:17

Jonathan and Ahimaaz: See [15:27](#), [36](#). • The location of En-rogel is uncertain, but it cannot have been too far east of Jerusalem.

2 Samuel 17:18-20

Bahurim was the home of Shimei, the pro-Saul Benjaminite ([16:5](#); [19:16](#)). Shimei's cursing of David at Bahurim reflected David's decline, while the escape of Ahimaaz and Jonathan pictured the hope of David's resurgence.

2 Samuel 17:23

hanged himself: Ahithophel foresaw David's victory and Absalom's undoing, and he preferred to die by his own hand rather than by David's.

2 Samuel 17:24

Mahanaim, once the capital city of Ishbosheth and Abner ([2:8](#), [12](#), [29](#)), became David's base of operations.

2 Samuel 17:25

According to [1 Chr 2:15-16](#), Abigail and Zeruiah were David's sisters. But since Abigail is called the

daughter of Nahash, she and Zeruiah were apparently David's half sisters (Nahash was probably their father; his widow would then have married Jesse and given birth to David and his brothers).

2 Samuel 17:27

Shobi was probably the brother of Hanun, who had humiliated David's messengers after the death of Nahash (ch [10](#); see study note on 10:1–5). • Makir was Mephibosheth's host before David summoned him ([9:4–5](#)). • Barzillai of Gilead was probably not the same as Barzillai from Meholah ([21:8](#)).

2 Samuel 18:3

You are worth 10,000 of us: Although David's men flattered him, their insistence that he stay behind might actually suggest David's advancing frailty (see [21:15–17](#)).

2 Samuel 18:5

Joab violated David's order to deal gently with young Absalom ([18:11–15](#)). This was the second time Joab killed someone against David's wishes (see [3:22–37](#)).

2 Samuel 18:6

The forest of Ephraim was an area east of the Jordan settled by the tribe of Ephraim.

2 Samuel 18:8

more men died because of the forest: The topographical conditions of the forest apparently took away the numerical advantage of Absalom's forces.

2 Samuel 18:9

Absalom, who took such pride in his hair, died because of it. He who had built "a monument to himself" ([18:18](#)) was then thrown into a pit after his death ([18:17](#)) and denied the dignity of a proper

burial. These ironies highlight the difference between Absalom's aspirations and his destiny.

2 Samuel 18:11

Perhaps a hero's belt was a sword belt that decorated a soldier for bravery and courage in battle (cp. [1 Sam 18:4](#)).

2 Samuel 18:14

plunged them into Absalom's heart: Earlier, Joab had played the role of reconciler between David and Absalom (ch [14](#)). It is possible Joab believed that allowing Absalom to live would only invite ongoing trouble for David and for himself. (Absalom had appointed Amasa, Joab's first cousin, to fill Joab's position as commander of Israel's army; see [17:25](#).)

2 Samuel 18:15

surrounded . . . and killed him: Perhaps Joab had his armor bearers finish the job so that he could make the case to David that he himself had not killed Absalom.

2 Samuel 18:17

all Israel fled to their homes: Absalom's supporters ([17:11](#)) knew their lives were in danger (cp. [19:8](#)). They had backed a usurper whose coup d'état had been thwarted.

2 Samuel 18:18

I have no son: See study note on 14:27. In the absence of a lineage, Absalom hoped a monument would preserve his name and memory. • to this day: The narrator was probably writing during Solomon's reign; the monument's location is now unknown.

2 Samuel 18:19

Zadok: See study note on 15:24.

2 Samuel 18:21

a man from Ethiopia: Joab thought it would be better to send a foreigner to tell the king of Absalom's death. If David overreacted, the loss of a foreigner was not as critical as the loss of a priest's son.

2 Samuel 18:25

If he is alone, he has news: A solitary runner was usually a courier.

2 Samuel 18:28–29

Everything is all right! (Hebrew shalom): David then asked, "Is it shalom with the young Absalom?" (What about young Absalom? . . . Is he all right?). Even though Absalom was David's rival, he was also David's son. David was more concerned about his son's fate than the well-being of his fighting servants ([19:5–6](#)).

2 Samuel 18:33

David was not afraid to show his emotions openly, whether engulfed by rapturous joy ([6:14–19](#)) or crushed by sadness. His feelings for Absalom were real, not theatrical.

2 Samuel 19:5–7

These verses provide the only recorded instance of Joab openly rebuking the king (cp. [24:3](#)).

2 Samuel 19:9–10

The argument among the tribes of Israel (possibly referring only to the northern tribes) resulted in the consensus that they should ask David to come back, perhaps instead of going back to the semiautonomy of the era of the judges (cp. [20:1](#)).

2 Samuel 19:11–12

When David realized that the northern tribes would welcome him ([19:9–10](#)), he sent emissaries

to goad Judah, his own tribesmen, into welcoming him as well. See also study note on [19:41–43](#).

2 Samuel 19:13

commander . . . in his place: Amasa's appointment would be short-lived ([20:7–10](#)).

2 Samuel 19:15

Gilgal was an important city in the days of Samuel and Saul (see study note on [19:40](#); [1 Sam 7:16](#); [11:15](#)).

2 Samuel 19:15–23

On his return to Jerusalem, David showed mercy to Shimei, the pro-Saul northerner who had cursed David when he fled from Jerusalem (see [16:5–14](#)), but Shimei's action did not go unpunished ([1 Kgs 2:8](#), [36–46](#)).

2 Samuel 19:17

Ziba: See [2 Samuel 16:1–4](#).

2 Samuel 19:20

I know how much I sinned: Shimei's repentance might have been genuine, or he might simply have been backpedaling in a desperate attempt to save his life. David's concern for Absalom's safety had shown that David was not a self-promoting, bloodthirsty throne-stealer, as Shimei had thought; and Absalom had not replaced him ([16:8](#)), as Shimei had charged. • in all Israel (literally *in all the house of Joseph*): Just as Jacob's name could stand for all Israel (e.g., [Num 24:19](#); [Isa 10:20](#)), Joseph's name could stand for all the northern tribes (e.g., see study notes on [Amos 5:6](#); [Zech 10:6](#)).

2 Samuel 19:21–22

Cp. [16:9–12](#). • Abishai: See study note on [16:9](#). • you sons of Zeruiah: See study notes on [2:18](#); [17:25](#). While it was Abishai who consistently wanted to kill those hostile to David (cp. [16:9](#); [1 Sam 26:8](#)),

David also expressed his frustration with Joab, Abishai's brother (see [2 Sam 3:28-29](#), [39](#); [19:13](#); [1 Kgs 2:5-6](#)).

2 Samuel 19:23

David's oath of protection was not binding on David's heir, Solomon, who later ordered Shimei's execution for far less serious crimes ([1 Kgs 2:36-46](#)).

2 Samuel 19:24

Mephibosheth's inattention to grooming throughout David's absence from Jerusalem was an act of mourning that proved his loyalty to David. If Mephibosheth had designs on the throne ([16:3](#)), he would not have retained such an unkempt appearance.

2 Samuel 19:24-30

See [2 Samuel 16:1-4](#).

2 Samuel 19:27-28

like an angel of God: See study note on 14:17. • I could expect only death . . . What more can I ask? If Mephibosheth had wanted to betray David, it would have been a profound show of ingratitude for all that David had done for him.

2 Samuel 19:30

Mephibosheth's disinterest in claiming even half of his property showed conclusively that his happiness over David's return was genuine.

2 Samuel 19:31

Gilead was part of Manasseh's territory on the east side of the Jordan ([Josh 17:5](#)).

2 Samuel 19:31-40

Because he was very old and frail, Barzillai declined David's invitation to the royal court in Jerusalem as reward for his assistance. David took Barzillai's son Kimham instead (see also [1 Kgs 2:7](#)).

2 Samuel 19:39

kissed him: This was a genuine and affectionate kiss, in contrast with David's cold kiss for Absalom ([14:33](#)) and Absalom's calculating one for the people ([15:5](#)).

2 Samuel 19:40

Gilgal, a natural stop along David's westward route, was also a politically significant location: It was where the people had proclaimed Saul king ([1 Sam 11:15](#)) and Samuel later announced the end of Saul's reign ([1 Sam 13:13-15](#)). David's kingship now had a new beginning at Gilgal.

2 Samuel 19:41-43

This dispute, prompted by David's favoring his own tribe of Judah, reflects the roots of the division that eventually split Judah and Israel into separate nations ([1 Kgs 11:31](#); [12:16](#), [20](#)). • Weren't we the first: See [2 Sam 19:11-12](#).

2 Samuel 20:1

Down with the dynasty of David! By the same rallying cry, the northern Israelites later dissociated themselves from Solomon ([1 Kgs 12:16](#)). Sheba's failed revolt foreshadowed the ultimate failure of the northern kingdom, which was founded on a similar revolt by Jeroboam ([1 Kgs 12](#)).

2 Samuel 20:3

The fate of the ten concubines ([15:16](#)) whom Absalom had publicly violated ([16:21-22](#)) was like Michal's (see [6:23](#) and corresponding note).

2 Samuel 20:4-5

The king had installed Amasa in Joab's place as commander of the armies ([19:13-14](#)). David apparently expected from Amasa the same efficiency and effectiveness as Joab had provided.

2 Samuel 20:7

the king's bodyguard: See study note on 8:18.

2 Samuel 20:9

to kiss him: This affectionate greeting was not always genuine (cp. [14:33](#)).

2 Samuel 20:10

Amasa . . . died: For the second time, Joab killed a commander of the opposing army by treachery (the first was Abner, [3:26-27](#)). Twice, David tried to merge feuding parties by absorbing the military leader of the opposing side (see [3:6-13](#); [17:25; 19:13](#)); twice Joab scuttled David's plans by treacherously murdering the rival commander (see also [3:22-30](#)).

2 Samuel 20:14

Abel-beth-maacah was in the northernmost region of Israelite territory, four miles west of the city of Dan.

2 Samuel 20:15

A siege ramp was often an earthen ramp built up against the wall, a well-known tactic for breaching a walled city's defenses (see also [2 Kgs 25:1](#); [Jer 52:4](#)).

2 Samuel 20:16

wise woman: Cp. [14:2](#).

2 Samuel 20:18-19

The woman told a saying to convince Joab not to slaughter an entire city, especially such a noble city as Abel (a shortened form of Abel-beth-maacah, [20:15](#)), just to capture one criminal. • an important town in Israel (literally *a town that is a mother in Israel*): It was common to refer to outlying villages around a larger city as its "daughters."

2 Samuel 20:23

In [8:16](#), Joab was called "commander of the army," but here he is commander of the army of Israel. David's wider control of Israel was established when the northern secessionist movements were defeated.

2 Samuel 20:23-26

This list of David's leaders and the similar list in [8:15-18](#) bracket chs [9-20](#) in David's life. Even after the major crises described in these 12 chapters, David's monarchy did not fall apart; he still had an intact administration.

2 Samuel 20:24

Adoniram: The addition of the officer in charge of forced labor (not mentioned in [8:15-18](#); see also [1 Kgs 4:6](#)) shows that David had now gained sufficient control of Israel to require the payment of taxes and to conscript labor throughout the kingdom (cp. [1 Sam 8:11-17](#)).

2 Samuel 20:25

In contrast to David's personal priest (see [8:18; 20:26](#) and corresponding notes), Zadok and Abiathar presided over public worship.

2 Samuel 20:26

David's personal priest was probably not a Levite but rather a special class of religious servant appointed for his royal court (see study note on 8:18)

2 Samuel 21:1

asked the Lord: The Hebrew verb is the same as that used when David “begged” for the life of Bathsheba’s child ([12:16](#)). On these two occasions, “seeking” was in the desperation of a moment of crisis. However, most often in the Old Testament, “seeking God” refers not to a specific prayer of petition but to the dynamics of daily devotion and obedience to God (e.g., [Pss 40:16](#); [105:4](#); [Prov 28:5](#)). • Saul and his family are guilty: The famine resulted from violating an oath taken before the Lord ([Josh 9:19–20](#)). • murdering the Gibeonites: This incident is not elsewhere recorded. Illicit bloodshed had polluted the land, making it sterile and unfruitful (cp. [Gen 4:10–12](#); [Num 35:30–34](#)).

2 Samuel 21:1–24.25

The final chapters of 2 Samuel are a *coda*, a concluding section that summarizes the important themes from the preceding material. These chapters are thematic, not chronological, and not all the events described here happened at the end of David’s reign (e.g., [22:1](#)). The materials are arranged according to a common Hebrew literary device, a *chiasm* (mirror-image): A: Saul’s sin against the Gibeonites and its collective punishment ([21:1–14](#)); B: David’s heroes and their exploits ([21:15–22](#)); C: David’s Psalm ([22:1–51](#)); C’: David’s Psalm ([23:1–7](#)); B’: David’s heroes and their exploits ([23:8–39](#)); A’: David’s sin against the census taboo and its collective punishment ([24:1–25](#)). A chiasm highlights the central section—here David’s hymns, which focus not on David but on David’s God.

2 Samuel 21:2

Though the Amorites were a specific people group ([Gen 10:16](#)), here it is a general term for the pre-Israelite inhabitants of Canaan. • When properly directed, zeal is commendable (e.g., [Num 25:11](#); [1 Kgs 19:10](#)). Saul’s misdirected zeal, however, involved blatant disregard for Israel’s covenant with the Gibeonites.

2 Samuel 21:3

Saul’s actions had caused the Gibeonites to curse Israel (cp. [Rom 2:24](#)); once David had made

amends, the Gibeonites would bless the Lord’s people again.

2 Samuel 21:6

seven of Saul’s sons: Although the law codes of other ancient Near Eastern nations sometimes permitted members of a family to be punished for crimes a guilty individual had committed, [Deut 24:16](#) prohibited such punishment among the Israelites. This penalty was God’s prerogative alone ([Deut 5:9](#)). The few instances in the Bible when offspring were punished were not regular criminal cases. Rather, they involved offenses against God, such as violation of the *kherem* (the taboo on goods in wars of total destruction ordered by God; [Josh 7:24–25](#)) or of national oaths (as here). • at Gibeon, on the mountain of the Lord: This probably refers to the high place at Gibeon that Solomon later visited ([1 Kgs 3:3–4](#); [2 Chr 1:3](#)). If the Hebrew reading is correct (see NLT note), the Gibeonites were sarcastically referring to Saul as “the chosen of the Lord.”

2 Samuel 21:7

the oath: See [1 Sam 20:14–15](#). In contrast to Saul, David was honoring his oath while dealing with the deadly fallout of Saul’s violation of an oath.

2 Samuel 21:8

Armoni and Mephibosheth were Saul’s only two remaining sons. • Saul’s daughter Merab: See NLT note; the NLT follows the Greek here because Michal remained childless ([6:22–23](#)). Also, Merab was married to Adriel ([1 Sam 18:19](#)), whereas Michal’s other husband was Palti ([2 Sam 3:15](#)). • Barzillai from Meholah (cp. [1 Sam 18:19](#)) should not be confused with Barzillai of Gilead ([2 Sam 19:31](#)).

2 Samuel 21:9

The beginning of the barley harvest was in April. • Before the Lord means “before the Lord’s altar” (see study note on 21:6).

2 Samuel 21:10

Because the Gibeonites were not Israelites ([21:2](#)), they had no law such as the Israelite one in [Deut 21:22-23](#) requiring the quick and proper burial of a criminal. Rizpah was intent that her sons not be further shamed after their death.

2 Samuel 21:11-13

Rizpah's action shamed David into likewise honoring the dead of Saul's family.

2 Samuel 21:14

The precise location of Zela is unknown. • the famine: See [21:1-2](#).

2 Samuel 21:15

The description of David as weak and exhausted helps shift the focus from his ability and accomplishments to God as the source of his success (ch [22](#)).

2 Samuel 21:15-22

The extended account of battles with the Philistines highlights some notable accomplishments of David's mighty warriors (see also [23:8-39](#)).

2 Samuel 21:16

a descendant of the giants: Cp. [Gen 14:5](#); [Deut 2:10-11](#), [20-21](#); [3:11](#).

2 Samuel 21:17

Abishai was an accomplished warrior and fiercely loyal to David, whom he heroically rescued (see "Abishai" Profile). • the light of Israel? Cp. [18:3](#). Both passages reflect the glowing adoration that David's men had for him.

2 Samuel 21:18

The location of Gob is uncertain.

2 Samuel 21:19

Some traditions identify Elhanan as David, principally because Elhanan was also from Bethlehem and because David killed Goliath ([1 Sam 17:48-51](#)). But it is more likely that the words *brother of* were omitted from the Masoretic Text by scribal error.

2 Samuel 22:1-51

Although this prayer of thanksgiving (also recorded in [Ps 18](#)) is placed near the end of David's story, David probably offered it to God much earlier in his life. This prayer and Hannah's ([1 Sam 2:1-10](#)) together enclose the book of Samuel with an *inclusio* (literary bookends). Hannah was saved from barrenness; David was saved from his enemies. The placement of this hymn also provides a parallel to Moses. The stories of both Moses and David end with a song or hymn giving lavish praise to God (see also [Deut 31:30-32:43](#)). Both highlight God as a "Rock" ([Deut 32:4](#), [15](#), [18](#), [30](#), [31](#); [2 Sam 22:2](#), [3](#), [32](#), [47](#)). Both are followed by second and shorter poetic pieces—Moses' final blessing to the Israelite tribes ([Deut 33](#)), and David's last words ([2 Sam 23:1-7](#)).

2 Samuel 22:2

Hannah had said, "there is no Rock like our God" ([1 Sam 2:2](#)), while David said, the Lord is my rock, which recalls God's rescue of David from Saul at the Rock of Escape ([1 Sam 23:28](#)). The Hebrew word translated "rock" in [22:3](#) (different from [22:2](#)) refers in [1 Sam 24:2](#) to "the rocks of the wild goats," where Saul suspected that David was hiding. • fortress: The same word referred to David's physical "stronghold" ([1 Sam 22:4](#)), where David and his men sought refuge from Saul.

2 Samuel 22:3

The phrase the power that saves me (literally *the horn that has saved me*) is similar to Hannah's "the

Lord has made me strong!," (literally *the Lord has exalted my horn*, [1 Sam 2:1](#)).

2 Samuel 22:7

Although his sanctuary sometimes refers to the Tabernacle or Temple, here it refers to God's heavenly dwelling; neither the Tabernacle nor the Temple were in existence at this time.

2 Samuel 22:8–20

David vividly expands on how God heard him ([22:7](#)). David describes God's rescue as a *theophany* (manifestation of God's presence; see study notes on Exod 19:16–25; Deut 1:33) that recalls God's manifestation at Sinai ([Exod 19:16–20](#); cp. [Judg 5:4–5](#)).

2 Samuel 22:14

The Lord thundered from heaven: Cp. [1 Sam 2:10](#).

2 Samuel 22:21–30

David's divine rescue and success were related to his own obedient walk with God. God honors those who order their lives in a way that pleases him (see also [Lev 26:1–13](#); [Deut 28:1–14](#); [Ps 1](#)).

2 Samuel 22:22–24

David composed these words much earlier ([22:1](#)), before his sin with Bathsheba. Still, his claim to being blameless should not be construed as a claim to perfection. David was simply noting that he had kept the covenant and followed its law.

2 Samuel 22:31–51

David glorifies God for rescue in the past and for his promises to David's house for coming generations (see [7:8–16](#)).

2 Samuel 22:32

See [Isa 43:11](#); [44:6, 8](#); [45:5, 21](#).

2 Samuel 22:34

David probably encountered deer during his many days of hiding out in hilly terrain and caves ([1 Sam 19:11–27:12](#)).

2 Samuel 22:38–40

David's military accomplishments before he became king were impressive (see [1 Sam 17:12–58](#); [18:17–30](#); [23:1–5](#); [30:1–31](#)). Yet rather than exalting himself, David glorified God and gave him the credit.

2 Samuel 22:51

Cp. [7:5–29](#); [1 Sam 2:10](#).

2 Samuel 23:1

David's last words were not necessarily the last words he actually spoke (see [1 Kgs 1:16, 29–30, 33–35](#); [2:1–9](#)) but his final public expression of worship to God as king (cp. [1 Sam 12:1–25](#)). • David . . . speaks: The language indicates that he was about to utter an oracle, a revelation from God ([2 Sam 23:2](#)). • the sweet psalmist of Israel: For other references to David as musician and poet, see [1 Chr 23:5](#); [2 Chr 29:26, 27](#); [Neh 12:36](#); [Amos 6:5](#).

2 Samuel 23:1–7

This passage comes from the end of David's career and reflects on his experience as king, even as [ch 22](#) reflects on his experience before becoming king.

2 Samuel 23:2

The Spirit of the Lord speaks through me: David spoke of God, and in the process, God spoke through David.

2 Samuel 23:5

my family . . . everlasting covenant: David is referring to the prophecy Nathan made about David and his descendants ([7:12-16](#)). Jesus is the everlasting king who is the “descendant of David” ([Matt 1:1](#)).

2 Samuel 23:6

Compare [Psalm 1:4-5](#).

2 Samuel 23:8-39

This section is a listing of David’s elite warriors by name, the most prominent of whom are listed with a notable accomplishment. These warriors were some of the “iron tools” that God used to “chop down” the godless ([23:7](#)). • The list divides into the Three and the Thirty. Some Hebrew scholars have suggested that *the Thirty* be translated as “Officers.” If that is correct, then it is possible that *the Three* was originally a term for a specific military office.

2 Samuel 23:10

to collect the plunder: Cp. [1 Sam 30:9-10](#), [21-25](#).

2 Samuel 23:13

The cave of Adullam was a place of refuge for David from Saul (see [1 Sam 22:1](#)). • The valley of Rephaim was located between Bethlehem and Jerusalem (see [2 Sam 5:17-25](#)).

2 Samuel 23:15-16

remarked longingly: This Hebrew verb elsewhere carries the idea of excessive desire (see [Num 11:4](#), “began to crave”; [Ps 106:14](#), “desires ran wild”). It is unclear whether David’s craving for water was excessive, but it certainly led to dangerous exploits. • well by the gate: David had memories from his younger days of growing up in Bethlehem. The location of the well is unknown.

2 Samuel 23:17

This water . . . these men: When David poured the hard-won water on the ground, it did not signal ingratitude. Rather, he regarded the water as equivalent to the warriors’ blood; it represented life that only God was worthy to receive ([Lev 17:10-13](#); [Deut 12:23-24](#)).

2 Samuel 23:18-23

Here are examples of the prowess of Abishai and Benaiah. Elsewhere, Abishai was intensely combative toward David’s enemies, especially Saul ([1 Sam 26:6-9](#)) and Saul’s kinsman Shimei ([2 Sam 16:9-11](#)). Abishai had saved David’s life during one of the Philistine wars ([21:16-17](#)). • Benaiah appeared first as the commander of the mercenaries who served as David’s bodyguard, independent of the regular army ([8:18](#); [20:23](#)). He was also the leader of a 24,000-man division of the regular army that served the king in the third month of every year ([1 Chr 27:5-6](#)). He played a major role in Solomon’s ascension to the throne ([1 Kgs 1:32-49](#)) and became the commander of Solomon’s army, as Joab was for David.

2 Samuel 23:24

Asahel, David’s nephew, was killed by Abner during the war between David and Ishbosheth ([2:18-32](#)). Asahel’s inclusion here suggests that parts of these lists go back to the beginning of David’s career. • Elhanan son of Dodo should not be confused with Elhanan son of Jair ([21:19](#); [1 Chr 20:5](#)).

2 Samuel 23:39

The very last name mentioned is Uriah the Hittite. There is an earlier reference to his father-in-law, Eliam, father of Bathsheba ([23:34](#); see [11:3](#)). By contrast, the Chronicler, who never mentioned David’s sins against Bathsheba and Uriah, placed Uriah’s name inconspicuously in the middle of the list of David’s mighty men ([1 Chr 11:10-47](#)). This author not only described the sins ([2 Sam 11:1-27](#)) but puts emphasis on Uriah’s name by placing it at the end of this list. Uriah was no ordinary conscript but a loyal member of David’s elite guard, which makes David’s treachery against him all the worse. • There were thirty-seven in all: Only thirty-six

names are mentioned, assuming that “Shammah . . . from Harar” ([23:11](#)) is different from “Shammah from Harod” ([23:25](#)), and that “Benaiah son of Jehoiada” ([23:20](#)) is different from “Benaiah from Pirathon” ([23:30](#)). Perhaps the thirty-seventh warrior was Joab, who is mentioned only peripherally ([23:18, 37](#)) and is absent from the list of names. Many commentators say that he is excluded because he was David’s chief military leader and did not need to be included. The omission could also represent David’s long and troubled association with Joab, who was eventually executed when Solomon carried out David’s deathbed command ([1 Kgs 2:5–6, 28–34](#)).

2 Samuel 24:1

The reason God’s anger . . . burned against Israel is unknown (but see [Deut 4:25; 6:14–15; 29:22–28; 31:16–18](#)). • Caused . . . to harm reflects a Hebrew verb (suth) used elsewhere in the sense of enticing or inciting someone to do wrong ([1 Sam 26:19](#), “stirred you up against me”). Census-taking was usually unpopular with citizens, who resented it as an intrusion into their private affairs. They regarded it as a prelude to taxation or forced military service (see study note on 2 Sam 24:9). If David was motivated by pride or was preparing for an illegitimate war (as [24:9](#) might suggest), this might explain why it was a sin for him ([24:10](#)).

2 Samuel 24:2

Dan and Beersheba were the traditional northern and southern boundaries of Israel. This phrase meant the entire land of Israel.

2 Samuel 24:3

why . . . do you want to do this? Joab either realized that such a move would be unpopular among the people, or he believed that it was wrong before God.

2 Samuel 24:9

The phrase capable warriors shows that the census focused largely on those fit for military service. The total for Judah here might be rounded up from the total in [1 Chr 21:5](#); the different number for Israel

in [1 Chr 21:5](#) (1,100,000) might come from combining a regular standing army of 300,000 (elsewhere unrecorded) with the 800,000 discovered through the census.

2 Samuel 24:10

I have sinned: See study note on 24:1. David believed his sin was the cause of the plague and that the removal of his sin would make things right (see also [24:17](#)). It is clear, however, that Israel rather than David was the true object of God’s wrath ([24:1](#)).

2 Samuel 24:11

Gad . . . David’s seer appears only here and in [1 Sam 22:5](#). Seer is an early name for a prophet ([1 Sam 9:9, 19](#)). Unlike pagan magicians or sorcerers, biblical seers had divinely inspired visions (see also [2 Kgs 17:13; Isa 29:10; 30:9–10; Amos 7:12; Mic 3:7](#)) and functioned as God’s messengers.

2 Samuel 24:13

David had already experienced the first two options—fleeing from Saul and Absalom, and famine because Saul had murdered the Gibeonites ([21:1](#)). While three days of severe plague sounded less traumatic, 70,000 people perished ([24:15](#)).

2 Samuel 24:16

the Lord relented: God might stop his judgment when a third party intercedes for the intended target ([Exod 32:12–14](#)), when the sinful person repents ([Jer 18:8](#)), or simply because he decides to do so. • the death angel: Cp. [Exod 12:23](#). • A threshing floor was an unwallled space where harvested grain was threshed and winnowed to separate the kernels from the chaff. Gideon encountered God at a threshing floor ([Judg 6:37](#)). Araunah’s threshing floor later became the site of the Temple ([1 Chr 21:18–22:1; 2 Chr 3:1](#)). • Araunah the Jebusite: Even though David had taken Jerusalem from the Jebusites ([2 Sam 5:6–9](#)), he had not eliminated them or driven them away.

2 Samuel 24:17

I am the one who has sinned: David's earlier confession of sin was limited to his circumstances ("forgive my guilt," [24:10](#)); now he prayed for those he considered innocent (but see [24:1](#)) and offered to die in their place. • as sheep: David was the shepherd of Israel (see study note on 7:8).

2 Samuel 24:21

so that he will stop the plague: David did not know that God had already announced the end of the plague to the angel ([24:16](#)).

2 Samuel 24:25

David performed priestly functions when he built an altar, offered burnt offerings and peace offerings, and prayed for his people; in response, the Lord answered his prayer (cp. [21:14](#)).